

TOOL

Guide For Defining User Personas

Instructions:

There is nothing more important than clarifying the types of people who use your product and how they get value out of it. Personas enable you to put your customers at the center of your discussions when you are planning your roadmap and making critical decisions. They also enable you to describe, humanize, and refer to your customers in a succinct and simple way.

Personas identify the characteristics, motivations, and goals that groups of customers share in common and impact how they interact with your product. Relevant factors vary depending whether your user base consists of large enterprise customers, small to mid-sized business owners, or consumers. You can use the following tool to help you find the patterns that will matter for your specific product, enabling you to write effective personas for your business.

This list is not exhaustive, but meant as a thought-starter so you can begin identifying your own personas.

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Enterprise

Things to Consider:

Job function: Are you selling to marketers, engineers, sales teams, CEO's, anybody who works at the company? Think carefully about who the primary target is.

Users vs. buyers: In enterprise software sometimes the user is not the person who makes the economic decision to purchase. So you may need multiple value props. Some customer relationship management software, for example, is disliked by users (sales people who enter data) but liked by the buyers (VP's of sales) who use it to manage their workforce and track results. Think about whether your users and buyers are different personas.

Demographics: Are there demographic patterns that matter for your product (age, life stage, location, etc.)?



Motivations: Are they risk-averse? Risk-seeking?

Goals: What's the most common goal for somebody in this role? Saving money? Increasing revenue? Getting promoted? Not getting fired?

Small business owners

Things to Consider:

Industry: What type of small-business owner? Local bike store, restaurant, financial advisor?

Staffing: Does the person have any staffing support? A one-person show will operate differently from somebody with a support staff.

Technology: Are they using old desktop computers running Windows? iPads? Smart phones?

Demographics: Are there demographic patterns that matter for your product (age, life stage, location, etc.)?

Motivations: Are they chasing profits at all costs? Are they more focused on passion than dollars (i.e. scuba dive shop focused more on diving than getting rich)?

Goals: What do they want to accomplish? Cost savings? More free time to pursue their passion? Maximizing revenue?

Consumer

Things to Consider:

Demographics: Which factors are specifically relevant to your product?

Motivations: What drives your customers?

Goals: What are your customers' most important goals that are relevant to the problem you're addressing?

